

« I miss the *junoon* among youngsters »

# SHAHBAZ AHMED

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**M**ornings in Lahore are unhurried. As the city slowly stirs to life, a steaming cup of doodh patti tea, flaky parathas, and a serving of halwa are breakfast staples.

But Shahbaz Ahmed Sr. is an early riser, known for his punctuality.

It was no surprise that he arrived at the roof-top cafe on MM Alam Road — nestled in the heart of the city — 10 minutes ahead of schedule. As he put it, it's this 'discipline' that keeps him going.

A former Pakistan hockey captain and a legend of the game, Shahbaz was renowned for his razor-sharp passes to centre-forwards, earning him the title of 'Maradona of hockey'. While he appreciates the moniker, he is deeply saddened by the current state of Pakistan hockey.

Over a breakfast of paratha and garam *ande* (eggs) — two quintessential Lahori delicacies — a nostalgic Shahbaz reminisced about leading Pakistan to victory at the 1994 World Cup in Sydney, one of the nation's greatest triumphs in its 'national sport'.

Midway through the conversation,

nostalgia took over. Shahbaz paused, picked up his phone, and dialled an old friend — former India captain M.M. Somaya — to relive past memories. He acknowledged that the Odisha government's investment and support have significantly boosted Indian hockey in recent years.

In an exclusive chat with *Sportstar*, the former captain and erstwhile administrator reflected on Pakistan hockey's golden years and how the country has struggled to sustain its rich legacy.

**What are your thoughts on the current state of Pakistan hockey?**



**If you look at our players' statistics, their ball possession and touch rates barely exceed 10-15 minutes across three or four tournaments. That's simply not enough for players aiming to compete at the highest level.**

Hockey has struggled to attract young players, and our performances in major international events reflect that decline. We are out of the World Cup and the Olympics, and there is no guarantee of jobs for those who take up the sport. As a result, the younger generation has moved on.

We have talent, but there is a lack of passion. I miss that *junoon* — the hunger among young players to step up, play the game, and carry forward the legacy.

Another major issue is that after playing at the local or junior level for a few years, many players leave to compete in sub-standard overseas